

Chapter 18: Confession

After nightfall, the evening breeze blew in through the window, carrying away the smoke that lingered around the two of them.

Yan Lin stood there, the cigarette at her fingertips unsmoked, letting the tiny sparks consume it completely.

Fu Sixue's words rang like an alarm bell in her mind, reverberating loudly.

"Speaking of which, if you don't even know whether you like Little Moon or not, why did you marry her?" Fu Sixue frowned, obviously disapproving of Yan Lin's approach.

Yan Lin extinguished what little remained of her cigarette: "Marriage was her idea." But just as she finished speaking, she froze in place like she'd been nailed there, rigid and motionless.

Fu Sixue sighed and was about to lecture her when she noticed something was wrong, straightening up to ask: "A-Lin, what's wrong with you?"

Yan Lin opened her mouth, but found she couldn't make a sound. Her wide-open eyes were already showing signs of redness.

"A-Lin! A-Lin, snap out of it! What's wrong!"

Yan Lin's gaze focused on Fu Sixue's face, then she said hoarsely: "She... she asked me the same thing..."

Fu Sixue frowned in confusion.

"I remembered... that night on our wedding anniversary, she asked me the same thing, asked me why I would marry her if I didn't like her..."

Fu Sixue had a bad feeling: "You... how did you answer?"

"I said... marriage was what you demanded..."

Fu Sixue fell silent. After a long while, she finally burst out with a vigorous curse.

"Fuck!"

Fu Sixue paced back and forth. She wanted to scold Yan Lin, but seeing her current distracted state, she couldn't bring herself to speak. But if she didn't say something, she felt sorry for Feng Yue.

"I'm telling you, are you confused?! I think you really know how to hurt someone in the most painful way possible." Fu Sixue scratched her head in frustration. "You're really going for the heart¹. Little Moon's ability to endure you for so long is truly remarkable!"

"I remember, that night I was out at a business dinner, drinking. She prepared so much food at home and waited for me until midnight... and I said something like that..." That sentence was like a key, unlocking all of Yan Lin's memories from that night.

"Didn't you think to apologize the next day?"

Yan Lin looked dazed: "The next day I had to go abroad on a business trip, very early flight..."

"So you just left?"

Fu Sixue looked at Yan Lin's silent expression and had her answer. She took a deep breath, trying to stabilize her emotions: "A-Lin, if we weren't best friends, I would have started a fight with you by now..."

Fu Sixue couldn't understand it. During middle and high school, Yan Lin's personality wasn't this cold, and she wasn't this dense either. Now she really was useless at everything except work, but first place at making her wife angry.

The two had come out under the pretense of using the bathroom, so they couldn't stay outside too long.

After this incident, Fu Sixue really felt sorry for Feng Yue. She even wanted to advise Yan Lin to just sign the divorce papers.

She was indeed Yan Lin's best friend, but she also hoped Feng Yue could be happy.

So during this welcoming dinner, Fu Sixue, the guest of honor, ate without taste, like chewing wax².

However, she chatted quite happily with the other ladies during the meal.

Except with Yan Lin.

Yan Lin sat there in a daze, her mind completely occupied with what Fu Sixue had said to her.

Actually, Yan Lin had forgotten that she had once said such things to Fu Sixue during that hot spring trip. It turned out she had already noticed Feng Yue's feelings for her back then.

But how could she have forgotten?

Yan Lin carefully recalled that time when her life consisted of nothing but studying. And Feng Yue, no matter what happened, always stayed by her side. Over time, she had taken this for granted, ignoring Feng Yue's own thoughts.

Because no one develops feelings of love or dislike for their own "habits" - "habits" are things carved into one's bones.

Because she knew that even if Fu Sixue left, Feng Yue wouldn't leave, would always stay with her.

But now the divorce papers Feng Yue had presented clearly told her that Feng Yue could leave. As long as Feng Yue was willing, they could have nothing to do with each other.

And she, Yan Lin, would be left behind, losing Feng Yue forever. Just like in her previous life, losing her beloved forever.

As for Yan Lin's "habit," this had nothing to do with Feng Yue. This was Yan Lin's own business.

Feng Yue sat next to Yan Lin, watching her completely absent-minded appearance, feeling somewhat puzzled.

Logically, with Fu Sixue back, the happiest person should be Yan Lin, her childhood best friend. But now she couldn't see a trace of joy on her face.

However, Feng Yue didn't plan to meddle in Yan Lin's affairs. Perhaps in the past she would have actively tried to understand Yan Lin's thoughts, but not anymore. She and Yan Lin were destined to part ways, and she was unwilling and saw no need to concern herself with such matters anymore.

When they were leaving, Fu Sixue exchanged contact information with everyone, even Wen Zhen's. Her reason was that she had a thing for collecting beautiful women³.

Yan Lin's driver had been waiting outside. Feng Yue, who was originally going to ride home with Wen Zhen, had to get in Yan Lin's car instead, since they were still nominally husband and wife.

As soon as she got in the car, Feng Yue's previously smiling expression turned cold, while Yan Lin sitting beside her was obviously restless.

The two remained silent the entire way. Even after getting out of the car, Feng Yue was the first to walk ahead without looking back.

Yan Lin had something to say to her, so she quickly caught up.

It was probably around nine o'clock at night, and Liu Ma had long since gone to rest.

Feng Yue opened the door and pressed the wall switch, lighting up the entire living room.

"A-Yue." Yan Lin closed the door and called Feng Yue's name.

Feng Yue knew she had been holding something back the entire way, so she simply took out her medicine to take.

"If you have something to say, just say it. I'm taking my medicine."

Yan Lin couldn't read her mood and didn't know if she was still angry. She felt like her ability to read people in business had become ineffective when it came to Feng Yue.

Yan Lin stood next to Feng Yue, her constantly intertwining fingers revealing her helpless mood: "A-Yue, I... I want to apologize to you."

Feng Yue continued her actions without stopping, still calmly taking her medicine pill by pill.

Yan Lin bit her lower lip and frowned: "What I said that night on our wedding anniversary wasn't intentional. I'm sorry. Please don't be angry anymore, okay?"

Upon hearing this, Feng Yue paused her actions, even her breathing stopped for a moment. She hadn't expected Yan Lin to apologize for this matter, and she hadn't expected that Yan Lin actually knew she would be angry upon hearing those words.

So, since she knew, why hadn't she come to apologize earlier? Why wait until after she had already handed over the divorce papers to make amends?

What was the point?

Feng Yue let out an imperceptible sigh: "You weren't wrong about that. I'm not angry with you anymore."

She continued, with a self-mocking smile at the corner of her mouth: "Actually, you were right. Marriage was indeed my idea. I was the one who confessed first, I was the one who proposed, I even prepared the rings. That we've come to this point today was entirely my own stubborn insistence. So you don't need to apologize - you don't owe me anything."

After saying this, Feng Yue put the remaining medicine in her mouth, then tilted her head back to drink some water, swallowing with difficulty.

"No, no that's not..." Yan Lin frowned tightly: "No one could force me to marry. I agreed because I was willing to. I was willing to marry you."

Feng Yue didn't want to continue this conversation with her, and silently stood up to return to her room.

Yan Lin grabbed her wrist, becoming agitated: "A-Yue, don't get divorced. I like you. Let's not get divorced. I'll accompany you through your treatment, accompany you to do everything you want to do. We can go back to how things were!"

By the end, Yan Lin's voice seemed somewhat hoarse and trembling, as she said quietly: "Don't... get divorced..."

Feng Yue's feet seemed nailed to the spot, unable to take a step.

Yan Lin liked her?

How long had she waited to hear this sentence? Feng Yue could no longer remember.

During their student days, she had never heard Yan Lin say this, because the Yan Lin of that time would silently treat her well, but wouldn't say much more. She thought this was also a form of love.

Later, after graduation, entering society, Yan Lin had something more important in her heart than treating her well - her career.

So she lost the only thing from which she could see Yan Lin's feelings for her. She survived these years relying solely on that tiny bit of affection from their student days.

And now, hearing this sentence, Feng Yue only felt disgusted.

The "like" she had once treasured had become a cheap tool to win her back.

A wave of dizzying nausea appeared before Feng Yue's eyes. She seemed unable to steady herself and staggered two steps. Just as she was about to fall, fortunately Yan Lin reached out to support her.

"A-Yue, what's wrong with you?"

Her stomach began to churn, and Feng Yue couldn't stop the dry heaving.

She pushed Yan Lin away and stumbled toward the bathroom.

The medicine's effects had kicked in.

Feng Yue was like a drunk, hugging the toilet and vomiting non-stop. It felt like all the blood in her body was rushing to her brain, veins bulging on her forehead.

Yan Lin followed Feng Yue to the bathroom and, seeing her distress, helplessly crouched down to gently pat her back.

Feng Yue had to admit that Yan Lin had a natural ability to soothe her. Just like now, what was supposed to be prolonged nausea and dry heaving felt much more bearable under the familiar scent that surrounded her.

Seeing that Feng Yue's condition had improved a little, Yan Lin quickly got up to pour her a glass of warm water to rinse her mouth: "Rinse your mouth."

Feng Yue sat slumped on the floor as if drained of strength. She had no energy left in her entire body. She had really lost all face in front of Yan Lin.

Seeing her embarrassment, Yan Lin silently helped her up to lean against herself: "I'll carry you upstairs." Then she reached around Feng Yue's knees and lifted her horizontally.

Feng Yue didn't want to be stubborn and drowsily let her carry her upstairs.

Usually she took her medicine in her room, then hugged the toilet and dry heaved, resting enough before slowly crawling back to bed.

But today she was on the first floor, and she really couldn't crawl back up.

Yan Lin carried Feng Yue steadily back to the master bedroom. Just as she put her down, Feng Yue began struggling to get up: "I need to go back to my room."

"This is your room." Yan Lin looked down and pulled the covers over her.

Feng Yue didn't have the energy to argue with her and struggled silently to get up.

"Lie down and rest. I'll watch over you."

Feng Yue ignored her.

Yan Lin seemed to get angry, raising her voice and pressing down on Feng Yue's shoulders with both hands: "Be good!"

Feng Yue looked up at her and found that her hands gripping her shoulders were trembling, and even the corners of her eyes were somewhat red.

Feng Yue quieted down. She shouldn't provoke Yan Lin too much - she still needed her to sign the divorce papers.

Seeing Feng Yue lie down quietly, before Yan Lin could breathe a sigh of relief, she heard her say:

"I won't withdraw the divorce papers."

Footnotes:

¹ **Going for the heart (杀人诛心):** A Chinese idiom meaning to attack someone psychologically or emotionally in the most devastating way possible, literally "killing someone by attacking their heart/mind."

² **Like chewing wax (味同嚼蜡):** A Chinese idiom describing food that has no taste, often used metaphorically to describe something boring, uninteresting, or unenjoyable.

³ **Collecting beautiful women:** This is Fu Sixue's playful way of saying she likes to be friends with attractive women - not in a romantic sense, but as someone who appreciates beauty and enjoys surrounding herself with beautiful people.